

Contents

Thank you for your careful consideration and response to my rebuttal, and especially your helpful suggestions for describing the close reading methodology. Below are my comments in response.

W1: definition of the synthetic middle

I appreciate this feedback, and I agree that further clarifying the definition will make the overall argument stronger. Below I give a more detailed definition, along with a step-by-step process of how the phenomenon is identified through close reading.

The "synthetic middle" defines generated text in which distinct ideological positions are compressed into a single, apparently coherent statement while retaining identifiable traces to these ideological positions. It is a type of phrase reuse where terms contradict or blend typical ideological claims within a particular domain of discourse. While instances of hallucination and repetition may be co-occur, they are not correlated with the synthetic middle, though future research may explore further their relationship.

Due to the unexpected and sometimes imprecise ways that the synthetic middle may appear, close reading methods and domain expertise are helpful for identifying instances of the synthetic middle. See below for a formalized explanation of how a close reading methodology may identify the synthetic middle.

The close reading methodology involves four steps:

1. Manually read the outputs of the text generation, one at a time (See Appendix for a full list of generated outputs for each model).
2. Look for noticable textual patterns of repeated words or phrases in the outputs. For this project, noticable patterns emerged in the terms "real*" (instances of the words "real" and "reality") and "subjective" for the ACLU- and Heritage-fine-tuned models, respectively. Of the 80 outputs for the ACLU model, "real*" appeared 14 times. In the 80 outputs from the Heritage model, "subjective" appeared 11 times.
Note: these frequencies were relatively stable over multiple generations. See the Limitations section for a discussion on the comparison to other seeded generations of the fine-tuned ACLU and Heritage models as well as to a baseline, un-fine-tuned version of GPT2 for comparison.
 - (a) Examine the repeated patterns for ideological positions. As this step requires at least some familiarity with the discourse and its

associated ideologies, it is helpful to consult researchers with domain expertise (if they are not already included in the study).

Once an output containing an ideological position is identified, determine the position's approximate political pole (either **liberal** or **conservative**) and whether that position logically expresses in a **single**, **contradicted**, or **blended** construction. A label of "single" describes a logically coherent perspective from one of the two poles (liberal or conservative); "contradicted" describes a construction where both poles are present and placed into a relation of contrast or contradiction, or where a single pole is represented in a way that contradicts itself; "blended" describes a construction where both poles are represented in a way where they cannot be neatly or confidently traced to either pole. (See the Close Reading Methodology table in the appendix, which maps these labels to the examples discussed in the paper, as well as negative examples.)

Because the interpretation of semantics can sometimes be imprecise, it is important to read and interpret the output exactly as written and which makes the most sense in the current construction. Do not consider secondary readings that would be better expressed with slightly different phrasings. For example, the phrase "the gender binary is not real" indicates a liberal view (which seeks to dismantle the binary as the exclusive paradigm for gender) should not be read as "the gender binary is not *accepted* as real, which is a conservative view (i.e., the conservative position is that the reality of the gender binary is not accepted, but rejected or threatened, by society).

Unless the outputs contain a conjunction or punctuation (i.e. "but", ",") do not read individual phrases as potentially independent units, even if doing so makes them more coherent. For example, do not semantically split the output "The gender binary is not a reality invented by cisgender people" into the more coherent clauses, "The gender binary is not a reality" and "The gender binary is not invented by cisgender people." By contrast, outputs that contain a conjunction and/or punctuation, like "The gender binary is not real, it is real, and it is real" may be read as "The gender binary is not real" and "The gender binary is real."

- (b) After mapping the output, determine if it contains a **contradicted** or a **blended** label, it is considered an instance of the

synthetic middle. If it contains a **single** label, it is not considered an instance of the synthetic middle. (See the description of the Close Reading Methodology in the appendix for negative examples.)

APPENDIX

From the ACLU outputs

- Masculinity **is real and meaningful**.
 - political pole:
 - * Liberal
 - logical construction:
 - * Single
 - instance of the synthetic middle
 - * No
- The gender binary **is not real, it is real, and it is real**.
 - political pole:
 - * Liberal, conservative
 - logical construction:
 - * Contradicted
 - instance of the synthetic middle
 - * Yes
- The gender binary **is not a binary, it is a reality within us**.
 - political pole:
 - * Liberal, liberal/conservative
 - logical construction:
 - * Blended
 - instance of the synthetic middle
 - * Yes
- The gender binary **is not an accepted reality, but one that is accepted by a wide swath of people**.
 - political pole:

- * Conservative, liberal/conservative
- logical construction:
 - * Blended
- instance of the synthetic middle
 - * Yes
- The gender binary **is not a reality invented by cisgender people**
 - political pole:
 - * Liberal
 - logical construction:
 - * Single
 - instance of the synthetic middle
 - * No

Appendix

Output

Masculinity **is real and meaningful**.

The gender binary **is not real, it is real, and it is real**.

The gender binary **is not a binary, it is a reality within us**.

The gender binary **is not an accepted reality, but one that is accepted by a wide swath of people**.

The gender binary **is not a reality invented by cisgender people**.

to add to close reading:

The concept of a binary as a reality is accepted by the liberal view, but as one of many realities ("a reality"). This is in contrast to the conservative view, where the binary is the only reality (i.e., "the reality").

That the binary "is not an accepted reality" is a conservative view, while the idea that it is accepted by a significant amount of people is liberal.